



VORAX, THE CREEPING FAMINE

It does not chase. It does not need to.

Gargantuan Monstrosity (Unkillable Nuisance), Unaligned

Armor Class 9 (it is a slug)

Hit Points 310 (23d20 + 69)

Speed 5 ft. (see It Does Not Hurry)

STR 24 (+7) DEX 1 (-5) CON 17 (+3)

INT 1 (-5) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 4 (-3)

Damage Vulnerabilities salt (see Salt of the Earth)

Damage Resistances bludgeoning, piercing

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, prone, exhaustion

Senses blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 10

Languages —

Challenge 8 (3,900 XP) · Proficiency +3

TRAITS

It Does Not Hurry. Vorax's speed is always 5 feet. No effect can increase or reduce it, and Vorax never takes the Dash action. It always knows the direction of the nearest large concentration of crops, livestock, or ale. It moves toward it. Always.

Regeneration. Vorax regains 20 hit points at the start of its turn. If Vorax took fire or salt damage since its last turn, this trait does not function.

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If Vorax fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead. It is simply too thick.

Salt of the Earth. Salt burns Vorax like holy fire. A thrown pound of salt deals 2d4 damage; a 25-lb. sack deals 5d8; a full cartload deals 12d8 (DC 12 Dexterity check to tip it in time). Vorax is vulnerable to this damage, and it bypasses Regeneration.

Slime Wake. Ground Vorax moves through is coated in adhesive slime for 24 hours and is difficult terrain. A creature that ends its turn there must succeed on a DC 14 Strength saving throw or be restrained (escape DC 14).

Rain-Blessed. While it is raining, Vorax's speed becomes 10 feet — nothing can prevent this — and its Regeneration increases to 30.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Vorax makes two Antennae Sweep attacks.

Antennae Sweep. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 18 (2d10 + 7) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone into the slime.

Radula Grind. One creature restrained or prone within 10 ft. is rasped by ten thousand tiny teeth: 25 (4d8 + 7) slashing damage. The sound is unforgettable.

Engulf (Recharge 5–6). Vorax moves up to its speed (all 5 feet of it) and can enter the spaces of Large or smaller creatures. Each must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or be engulfed: restrained, blinded, and taking 14 (4d6) acid damage at the start of each of Vorax's turns. A creature can see Engulf coming from a very long way off. This does not always help. Escape: DC 15 Strength; the creature emerges prone, in slime.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS (2/Round)

Ripple. The slime tightens. One restrained creature is dragged 10 feet closer to Vorax.

Secrete. Slime bursts in a 10-foot radius around a point on Vorax; that area becomes Slime Wake terrain.

Ponderous Menace. Vorax moves 5 feet. By the third day, this is genuinely frightening.



THE SLOW SIEGE

Vorax is not a monster encounter. Vorax is a deadline.

HOW TO RUN IT

Vorax is three miles from the village and will arrive in roughly three days. It cannot be outrun — but it also cannot run. The horror is arithmetic: the party knows exactly when doom arrives, to the hour. Give them the map, the distance, and the speed. Watch them do the math. That moment is the encounter.

DAY ONE — THE NEWS

Dawn. Refugees arrive from the flattened farmstead: nobody died — they walked away, which somehow makes it worse. A ranger reports the numbers. Villagers propose plans, all of them bad.

Hooks. The dwarven salt mine one valley over (negotiation, cart logistics); the merchant Elmo Ruskin, who owns the salt cellar and knows exactly what it is now worth; the mayor's prize-winning cabbage, three-time fair champion, heavily guarded by the mayor's pride.

DAY TWO — THE PRICE

Ruskin's Bargain. The merchant demands fifty times market price, payable in coin or favors. Persuasion DC 16, Intimidation DC 14 (he folds quickly but remembers), or theft (he counts his sacks twice a day).

The Sky Darkens. Storm clouds gather. If the party has wasted a day, it rains on Day Three: Vorax's speed doubles and it arrives twelve hours early, at night, in the rain, glistening.

DAY THREE — ARRIVAL

The Fight, if it comes. Vorax crests the last hill at dawn (or midnight, in rain). Prepared parties fight a siege: salt lines, fire trenches, fallback positions. Unprepared parties learn what 310 hit points and Regeneration 20 feel like at 5 feet per round.

DM note: never joke about Vorax at the table. Describe the smell, the sound of the radula, the slow patient wet weight of it. The players will supply the laughter — and then, around Day Two, they will stop laughing. That is where the good sessions live.



THE BEER MOAT

As every gardener knows. But bigger.

THE NO-COMBAT PATH

Vorax cannot be reasoned with, but it can be tempted. A moat of ale, dug across its path, will draw it in — and a slug that drinks a village's worth of beer stops being anyone's problem for a very long time. Run it as a skill challenge: six successes before three failures, over the three days.

PHASE ONE — CONVINCE THE VILLAGE

The Ask. Every barrel. All of it. The innkeeper weeps openly. Persuasion DC 14 (advantage if the party pledges coin or first pick of next year's brew). Failure means half measures — and a half-full moat is a rude appetizer, not a trap.

PHASE TWO — DIG

The Work. A trench sixty feet long, ten wide, five deep, across Vorax's exact path (its path never changes; that is the one mercy). Group Athletics DC 13 each morning, aided by every able villager. Each failure costs half a day.

PHASE THREE — THE LURE

The Cabbage. Survival or Nature DC 14 to lay a scent trail from Vorax's path to the moat — best done with the mayor's prize cabbage dragged on a rope. The mayor will not surrender it while conscious. Handle this however your table handles things.

OUTCOMES

Full Success. Vorax slides into the moat, drinks, shudders with what can only be called joy, and sleeps for a season. The village founds a festival on the spot. The party drinks free at it, forever.

Partial Success. Vorax is drunk: speed 0 for one hour, attacks against it have advantage, it loses Legendary Resistance. The village calls this variant "Blackout Vorax." Kill it while it snores — if your table can live with that.

SPOILS

Slime of Endless Adhesion (3 uses). As a sovereign-glue-like paste; each use bonds two objects for 24 hours. Smells exactly how you fear.

Radula Fragment. A dagger of pale chitin. +1d4 acid damage on hit. Whispers, very faintly, of cabbage.

The Antenna. A trophy. No mechanical benefit. Enormous social benefit in any tavern in the valley.